human specimen, willing and more than able to lead America into the war against the Nazi menace.

Said Stephen Broussard, co-producer on *Captain America: The First Avenger*, "It was very much viewed as taking a stance, as controversial. The United States was just coming out of the Great Depression, just getting back on its feet. World War I was fresh in everyone's mind. It was very much viewed as Europe's war and Europe's problem — not by all, but by a large segment of the American population. So when you have Captain America punching out Hitler in March 1941, before Pearl Harbor, it's definitely a statement. It was definitely saying, 'We cannot sit by the sidelines anymore.'"

"The original Captain America was a propaganda tool, and it's very clear and it's way over the top. And it would be. It would be called flag waving and jingoism if it were published today for the first time," *Captain America* Director Joe Johnston said.

And it was that direct attempt to influence America's youth that led to Simon and Kirby finding themselves at the center of a heated controversy. "This was the time just before the war, and we were besieged by the American Boon members," Simon said. "They used to have big rallies at Madison Square Garden. They'd have fifty thousand people in the rallies. And they had a lot of sympathizers. They found out where we were, where we lived, and every day...the streets were crowded with the Boon members protesting and spitting on us...They were very aggressive people."

The protests grew so extreme that FBI agents were dispatched to the offices of Timely Comics — the publisher that would one day come to be known as Marvel — to protect the company's comic-book talent.

America soon entered World War II, and the protests dwindled. Captain America was on the front lines with his youthful sidekick, Bucky, fighting Nazi enemies like the horrific Red Skull. With his magazine selling almost in the millions, Captain America had captured the heart of his nation; his adventures even outsold mainstay newsstand publications like *Time Magazine*.

